

1967

The ARPANET

October: The beginning of the ARPANET

Work on the ARPANET begins. The US Military-sponsored ARPA (Advanced Research Projects Agency) realised the need to create a network of computers so as to protect its communication capabilities in case of any conflict (during the Cold War with the USSR). The ARPANET grew over time and the infrastructure and technologies developed for it fuel what is called the Internet today.

The Seed

Though ARPANET was a military-funded project, the active participation of the brightest minds from academia and business were sought. Since it was a first of its kind, the pioneers behind ARPANET had to create every aspect of the network and data transfer from scratch. The protocols were the critical first step since there were many different proprietary computer systems that would be connected to each other. The initial idea involved creating a separate computer tasked with managing the transfer of data between the host PC and the network. This computer was called the Interface Message Computer, and is the precursor to today's Router. The Network Control Protocol, a set of rules that allow the disparate computers to communicate with each other was the precursor to the present Transmission Control Protocol (TCP). The first node on ARPANET, which was established in 1969, was at UCLA (University of California, Los Angeles), which also had the facility to monitor network status. The second node, also set up in 1969, was at SRI (Stanford Research Institute). The first message was sent through the network in 1969 and it read: "lo". The first message was the result of an attempt to "login" to the computer at SRI from UCLA, but the system crashed midway. Two more nodes came up in 1969, at the University of California at Santa Barbara and the University of Utah.